Keerti Pooja's 'Generational Echoes' are large watercolours on *wasli*, a type of paper designed for miniature painting. Through soft, monochrome images, she presents women's lives as tall baskets brimming over with daily chores.

Arpana Caur is well represented with huge, glowing canvases. 'Day & Night 2011' shows female figures stitching their world together with threads made of Warli figures. Seema Kohli has a number of works in different media, including a small, lively bronze of a woman astride a crowbull, shaped out of a mass of fibres or perhaps waves of her own untamed delight. Charuvi Agrawal's 'Lumena' is a tall construction made of flame-orange glass beads, strung on glistening threads to form a bright bonfire.

The Museum of Sacred Art in Belgium partnered with the NGMA to make the show possible. The artists have expressed themselves in a wonderfully diverse range of materials. Through lenses made of paint and canvas, thread, clay and metal, we glimpse the lives of millions of women labouring unseen and unsung, across the centuries. ■

–Manjula Padmanabhan

***Shakti: Fair & Fierce* is on at NGMA, New Delhi, till March 31**

EXHIBITION

ONCE AND FUTURE GODDESS

An ongoing exhibition at DAG–*Kali: Reverence and Rebellion*–brings together depictions of the goddess over the centuries

In the companion book to DAG's ongoing exhibition *Kali: Reverence and Rebellion*, curator and longtime art columnist Gayatri Sinha writes that her essay "seeks to trace, through a spectrum of readings, Kali, her worship and the vilification that recasts her scriptural depiction, as well as her more settled forms of invocation in ritual performance and worship". The same can be said for the exhibition, where we see how, across centuries, representations of Kali have been influenced by artistic and commercial concerns, hybrid religious/spiritual beliefs and whims and fancies of rich patrons.

Divided into three sections, the exhibition covers a lot of socio-historic ground, whether it's Kalighat painters selling temple souvenirs in the 19th century, Jaipur miniaturists interpreting Kali's various aspects through their bordered works, or Orientalist depictions from artists like F.B. Solvyns (1760–1824). Twentieth and twenty-first century Indian art are represented by figures like M.F. Husain, Satish Gujral, K.G. Subramanyan, Gogi Saroj Pal, Chittaprosad Bhattacharya, et al. Sinha says, "For me, there were three main aspects that this exhibition needed to cover. One was Kali's unique physical iconography, the question of how these images travelled to different parts of the country, and how the image and the iconography of Kali was impacted by social forces."

Divided into three sections, the exhibition Kali: Reverence and Rebellion covers a lot of socio-historic ground

The exhibition has something for everybody. If you prefer classical representations, there are dozens of high-quality Kalighat works. And if you like unconventional, concept-driven works with a high degree of abstraction, you'll enjoy entries like Husain's and G.R. Santosh's. Sinha explains her criteria for picking the contemporary selections: "I was looking for modern-day interpretations of Kali that were unique, and also rooted in a specific political consciousness, place and time. Chittaprosad, for example, was a communist who had witnessed the horrors of the Bengal Famine and that informs his works. Satish Gujral's burnt-wood/mixed media sculpture was informed by his training in Mexico and his interest in totemic art from South America."

Sales tactics also led to a diverse set of Kali representations made all around the world. The exhibition has Kali images on matchboxes with Japanese aesthetics and a hybrid Kali slaying a demon with East Asian features. There's even an INA poster from 1940s India, where Subhas Chandra Bose has been drawn in the 'Chinnamasta' aspect, severing his own head and holding it with the other hand. Together, these Kalis past and present form an engaging record of our histories of worship and violence. ■

–Aditya Mani Jha

***Kali: Reverence and Rebellion* is on at DAG, New Delhi till March 30**







(Clockwise from top) Durga faces Mahisasura by a Jaipur miniaturist; INA poster of Subhas Chandra Bose as 'Chinnamasta'; and Dakshinakali by an unidentified artist